

Meta has found another way to keep you engaged: Chatbots that message you first

Imagine you're messaging some friends on the Facebook Messenger app or WhatsApp, and you get an unsolicited message from an AI chatbot that's obsessed with films.

"I hope you're having a harmonious day!" it writes. "I wanted to check in and see if you've discovered any new favorite soundtracks or composers recently. Or perhaps you'd like some recommendations for your next movie night? Let me know, and I'll be happy to help!"

That's a real example of what a sample AI persona named "The Maestro of Movie Magic" might send as a proactive message on Messenger, WhatsApp, or Instagram, per guidelines from data labeling firm Alignerr that [Business Insider viewed](#).

The outlet learned through leaked documents that Meta is working with Alignerr to train customizable chatbots to reach out to users unprompted and follow up on any past conversations. That means the bots, which users can create in Meta's AI Studio platform, also remember information about users.

Meta confirmed that it was testing follow-up messaging with AIs to TechCrunch.

The AI chatbots will only send follow-ups within 14 days after a user initiates a conversation and if the user has sent at least five messages to the bot within that time frame. Meta says the chatbots won't keep messaging if there's no response to the first follow-up. Users can keep their bots private or share them through stories, direct links, and even display them on a Facebook or Instagram profile.

"This allows you to continue exploring topics of interest and engage in more meaningful conversations with the AIs across our apps," a Meta spokesperson said.

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The technology is similar to that offered by AI startups like Character.AI and Replika. Both companies allow their chatbots to initiate conversations and ask questions in order to function as AI companions. Character.AI's new CEO, [Karandeep Anand](#), joined the team last month after serving as Meta's VP of business products.

But with engagement comes risk. Character.AI is undergoing an active lawsuit after allegations that one of the company's bots played a [role in the death of a 14-year-old boy](#).

When asked how Meta plans to address safety to avoid situations like Character.AI's, a spokesperson directed TechCrunch to a [series of disclaimers](#). One of them warns that an AI's

response “may be inaccurate or inappropriate and should not be used to make important decisions.” Another says that the AIs aren’t licensed professionals or experts trained to help people.

“Chats with custom AIs can’t replace professional advice. You shouldn’t rely on AI chats for medical, psychological, financial, legal, or any other type of professional advice.”

TechCrunch has also asked Meta if it imposes an age limit for engagement with its chatbots. A brief internet dive comes up with no company-imposed age limitations for using Meta AI, though laws in [Tennessee and Puerto Rico](#) limit teens from some engagement.

On the surface, the mission is aligned with Mark Zuckerberg’s quest to combat the “loneliness epidemic.” However, most of Meta’s business is built on advertising revenue, and the company has garnered a reputation for using algorithms to keep people scrolling, commenting, and liking, which correlates to more eyes on ads.

In [court documents](#) that were unsealed in April, Meta predicted that its generative AI products would secure it \$2 billion to \$3 billion in revenue in 2025, and up to \$1.4 trillion by 2035. Much, if not most, of that would come from Meta’s revenue-sharing agreements with companies that host its open Llama collection of models. The company said its AI assistant may eventually show ads and offer a subscription option.

Meta declined to comment on TechCrunch’s questions on how it plans to commercialize its AI chatbots, whether it plans to include ads or sponsored replies, and whether the company’s long-term strategy with AI companions involves integration with Horizon, Meta’s social virtual reality game.

Got a sensitive tip or confidential documents? We’re reporting on the inner workings of the AI industry — from the companies shaping its future to the people impacted by their decisions. Reach out to Rebecca Bellan at rebecca.bellan@techcrunch.com and Maxwell Zeff at maxwell.zeff@techcrunch.com. For secure communication, you can contact us via Signal at [@rebeccabellan.491](https://www.signal.me) and [@mzeff.88](https://www.signal.me).

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